

Recognize it

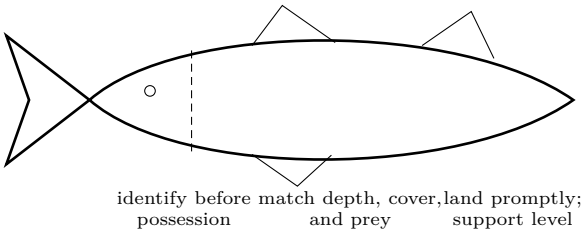
Deep colorful sunfish with turquoise cheek lines and orange/red mark on the ear flap.

Body	Mottled olive sides; orange belly; short rounded pectoral fin.
Mouth/fins	Small mouth; stiff spiny dorsal joined to soft portion.
Confusion	Bluegill lacks the bright ear-flap margin and has a longer pointed pectoral fin.

Lake role

Where it belongs
Vegetated shallows, snails and insect-rich edges, firm spawning pockets.
Food and season
Invertebrates, especially snails and insects; shallow during warm spawning period.

A fish-shaped decision, not a lure list



Find it on these waters

Pine	Test protected weed pockets and gravel/sand openings, then the first green outside edge.
North	Test shallow vegetation and firm pockets in protected bays.
Evidence	The DNR lake records sometimes name only a broad group such as panfish. In that case this species is a candidate member, not verified individual presence. Confirm presence before targeting; treat locations as testable habitat hypotheses, not abundance findings.

Presentations

- 1. **Tiny float rig.** Present a worm segment or insect imitation near weed openings without burying it.
- 2. **Micro-jig.** Pitch a compact jig to visible pockets and pause near bottom.
- 3. **Stop rule.** Move when only very small fish respond; do not strip a nesting colony for a meal.

HANDLING DECIDES THE OUTCOME

Fold the dorsal spines back, wet hands, and support the body rather than squeezing.

Water-specific rule	Open all year; no minimum; panfish daily bag 25 on both lakes as listed 2026-07-26.
Kitchen choice	Use a modest number of thicker mid-size fish; release exceptional adults and active nest guards.
Before the trip	Open the Wisconsin DNR water-specific regulation page for WBIC 779200 (Pine) or 850800 (North). Check the exact water, species, and date; the live rule controls if this dated sheet differs.

Keep only a fish you can use

Decide before the cast. Bring ice, stop fishing when the planned meal is secured, and use the species-specific cooking guide for dispatch, bone layout, and safe preparation. Large old predators are valuable spawners and generally carry more mercury than smaller fish.

Sources checked 2026-07-26. Wisconsin DNR lake fish records (Pine WBIC 779200; North WBIC 850800), Wisconsin’s Fishes, Hook Your Catch, 2026–27 water-specific regulations, Catch-and-release Guidelines, and Eating Your Catch. Biological and tactical synthesis is editorial; it is not a current population survey.

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